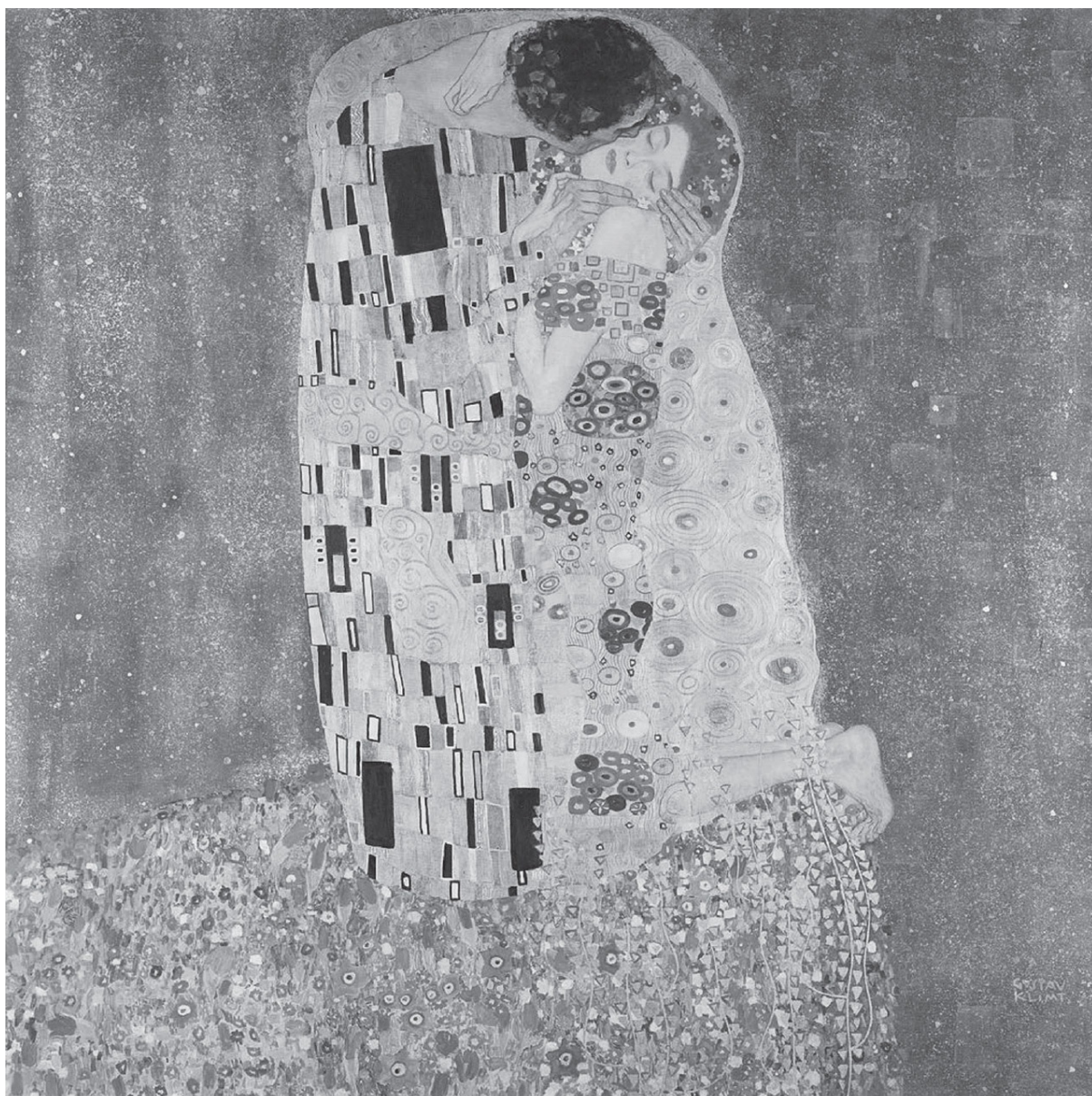


Klimt

Criticized for sensuality and eroticism in his time, but also highly admired, Austrian artist Gustav Klimt (1862–1918) produced highly ornamental paintings rich in Symbolist elements. His primary subject was the female form – images of pregnancy, motherhood and ageing, as well as portraits of society women – but he also painted stylized allegories and landscapes. A pivotal figure in Art Nouveau and the Vienna Secession, his later work was particularly expressive and vibrant. Inspired by influences from Impressionism, Symbolism and Dürer to Japanese, Classical Greek, Byzantine and ancient Egyptian art. His unique approach mixed mosaic-like flat patterns with a detailed, realistic, three-dimensional style.

After Klimt's paintings of c.1900 for the University of Vienna's Great Hall were denounced as pornographic, he refused further public commissions. For the next decade, he created jewel-like paintings featuring gold leaf and other rich embellishments. The period became called his 'Golden Phase' – although the content of some works continued to shock, it also attracted admiration.



Klimt, *The Kiss*, 1908–9